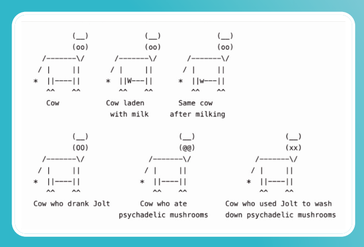
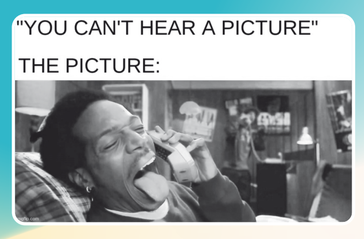
How have our* social lifes and media habits changed since the 1990s?

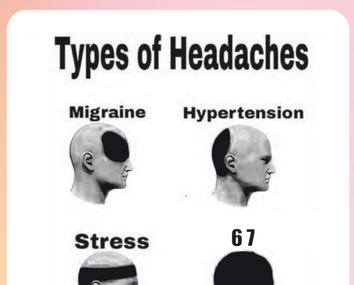
*people in Germany, aged 15-29 years old

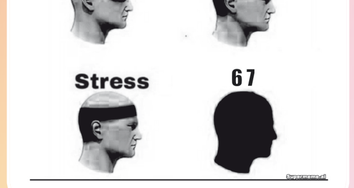
From 1990s to 2020s the media technology changed drastically, from the introduction of the internet and personal computers , all the way to the fight over our attention span by large corporates with the help of always-available and quick-to-reach smartphones combined with fast paced media formats like short-form videos plus intentional addiciting design patterns like the endless scroll and personalised algorithms.

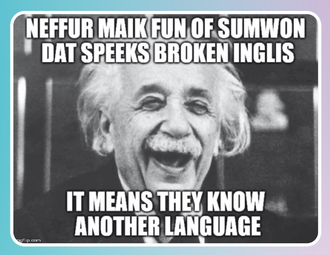
But how did that affect the broad youth in Germany? Did it lead to a general new time share of how we go through our day? Or were only parts of the youth society affected by it?

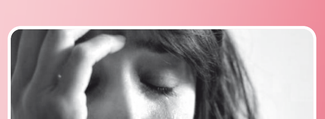












1990s

39

Visits peaked at an average of 39 minutes a day. The doorbell was the notification. Ignoring it meant hiding quietly behind the sofa.

wash
body
visitors/ visiting
house-hold chat
going out
cleaning/tidying up

2000s

house-hold chat
wash
body
homework
travel time for social life
going out

RealityTV@home! In-person house-hold chats peaked at 39 minutes a day on average in the 2000s. An unpaid cast. Stay tuned!

39

wash
body
house-hold chat
gaming (PC/Notebook)
local shopping
resting

2010s

33

PC/Smartphone use averaged 33 minutes a day in the 2010s. "use" meaning throwing your keyboard after Moving a picture in Word.

Local shopping (9) and resting (10) both peaked in the 2010s. That can't be a coincidence. Luckily we've evolved to sitting on the sofa while shopping.

9.
10.

wash
body
gaming (PC/Notebook)
visitors/ visiting
social media
courses prep/follow-up

2020s

8.

social media entered at 8th: 19 min a day, adding up to nearly five days a year. Just a quick look? More like you should pack underwear.

VS 1990s 2020s

Probably never the medium for the youth, flipping through a newspaper, sipping a coffee and being under 30 can only be sold by Philipp Amthor.

24.
45.
75.
93.

An image that never really suited us

From '90s to '20s, sleep gained 32 min a day on average. Somewhere between the alarm clock and phone alarm, snoozing got an extension.

+32

More exercising, less time reading the newspapers. Or seems like we found a way to cope with the current and future world events.

reading newspaper
4.

fitness & gymnastics
+4

1990s
2000s
2010s
2020s

After sleep and work our biggest constant: Watching a screen displaying about 60 images/s. TV, streaming, whatever your medium is.

1990s
2000s
2010s
2020s

Skyrocketing, and it all started with Minesweeper and Tetris. The only discussion that remains if you're a PC, console or phone gamer.

7.
travel time to work

+2
baking

More time commuting, less time baking. So much for the homeoffice sourdough fantasy. Trends suggest the starter has been abandoned.

Going out fell by 12 min a day on average from the '90s to the '20s. Disco wants to discuss its reduced role. Could have been an email.

-12

Building a house! Or at least renovating your home has probably thanks to more time at home, #covid, gained some ranks.

45.
88.
96.
106.

Call it a comeback for heavy-duty DIY?

More time eating, less time talking. Perhaps "don't talk with your mouth full" was the most effective communication policy ever.

household chats
9.

eating & drinking
+10

-15

Travel for social contact fell by 15 min a day on average from the '90s to the '20s. Replaced by snaps from the convenience of the toilet?

We found a way back to museums and art!

72.
103.
121.
123.

To be fair, never was really up there, but it seems like we found a way back to enjoying the craft of offline museums and art.

9.
reading

+8
theme parks, circus & fairs

More time for theme parks, less time reading. Perhaps we still enjoy a good story. We just want it to last 90s and turn us upside down.

kino.to? Wikipedia? Using the browser at all? Seems like we reached the browsing peak in the 2010s. Metaverse? Or what's next?

1990s
2000s
2010s
2020s

Eat this PISA, we do still read books!

28.
30.
41.
43.

Might help that reading books electronically also counts towards this activ ity. Nonetheless, reading books remains an activity we enjoy.

-11

DIY and repairs fell by 11 min a day on average from the '90s to the '20s. "I made this.", "I found this." Both look good on the feed.

share with your bff, bro, partner in crime, robot, grandma or neighbor

Research Data Centres of the Statistical Offices of the Federation and the Federal States. (2018d). Zeitverwendungserhebung 2022, PUF, Version 0 (Version 0) [Data set]. https://doi.org/10.21242/63911.2022.00.00.4.1.1

Research Data Centres of the Statistical Offices of the Federation and the Federal States. (2018c). Zeitverwendungserhebung 2012/2013, PUF, Version 0 (Version 0) [Data set]. https://doi.org/10.21242/63911.2013.00.00.4.1.0

Research Data Centres of the Statistical Offices of the Federation and the Federal States. (2018b). Zeitbudgeterhebung 2001/2002, PUF, Version 0 (Version 0) [Data set]. https://doi.org/10.21242/63911.2002.00.00.4.1.0

Research Data Centres of the Statistical Offices of the Federation and the Federal States. (2018a). Zeitbudgeterhebung 1991/1992, PUF, Version 0 (Version 0) [Data set]. https://doi.org/10.21242/63911.1992.00.00.4.1.0

Dancing Baby. [Meme]. Retrieved 27 October 2026, from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dancing_baby

Imgflip.com. [Meme]. Retrieved 27 October 2026, from https://imgflip.com/

Meme.com. [Meme]. Retrieved 27 October 2026, from https://meme.com

Supermeme.ai. [Meme]. Retrieved 27 October 2026, from https://supermeme.ai

Behind the scenes of this infographic: https://github.com/max-zwei/portfolio/tree/main/projects/infographics

20.11.2026